InSites: Significance Assessment through the Looking Glass of Gen-AI

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Who should join? Archaeologists and professionals in heritage management and conservation, educators, curators and anyone interested in communicating cultural values and curious about integrating Gen-AI tools into this complex task.

Description: Articulating significance, which is crucial in value-based heritage management, is a complex interpretive task requiring the synthesis of diverse and fragmented evidence. While Gen-AI offers powerful processing capabilities, delegating this creative process to a machine raises critical ethical concerns.

In this workshop, inspired by Lewis Carroll's novel *Through the Looking Glass*, we navigate this tension by positioning Gen-AI as a reflective partner. Using our *InSites* Human–AI agentic workflow, we will examine how transformer-based models complement Context-Based Significance Assessment (CBSA), as both fundamentally rely on deep contextual understanding. We move beyond the hype to ask: *Can Gen-AI transparently read and analyze the site documentation so humans can better "read the site" and conserve it*?

We will experiment with transforming site information (from excavation reports, etc.) into a structured assessment process, guiding users through "mini agents" steps in the InSites tool, each with optional training notes for learning purposes. We'll move from detecting missing information and identifying contexts and values to drafting explainable significance statements. Beyond writing, we will experiment with multivocal narratives, knowledge graphs, and interactive views, ranging from standard timelines to novel participant-invented visualizations, that help gain new cultural insights and communicate them in new ways.

The *InSites* workflow is grounded in three core Human–AI design principles: *methodological alignment* (embedding professional protocols), *cognitive transparency* and strict *evidence grounding*, which we will explore throughout the workshop sessions.

Workshop Program

1. **Theory & Demo:** An introduction אתם the CBSA methodology embedded in the system and how transformer models "mirror" it, followed by a live *InSites* demo.
2. **Hands-On Main Sessions:**
   - **Write with *InSites*:** Co-authoring a significance assessment for a site of the participants' choice alongside the agent workflow, including the generation of visual artifacts and interactive dashboards.
   - **Read with *InSites***: Analyzing the generated assessments to detect hidden patterns.
3. **Ethics in Practice:** Participants will apply the design principles to experiment with sketching a custom agent for their specific needs.

Workshop Takeaways

- A preliminary significance assessment report of the site and other generated artifacts.
- Hands-on experimentation with structured Human-AI collaboration workflows.
- Continued access to the *InSites* tool, website, and GitHub repository.

References

Alef, Y., & Shafriri, Y. (2023). *Cultural Significance Assessment of Archaeological Sites for Heritage Management in the Digital Age: From Text of Spatial Networks of Meanings*. https://doi.org/10.5281/ZENODO.8360843

European Archaeological Council. (2025). Assessing Archaeological Significance: Key Concepts (EAC Guidelines 9). European Archaeological Council. https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.10697000

GitHub Repository: https://github.com/InSites-Lab/Insites-CAA2026

Requirements: LCD projector, Wi-Fi

Attendee Requirements

- A Laptop and Wi-Fi.
- AI Access to a capable model (e.g., Gemini pro, ChatGPT Plus, DeepSeek etc.)
- Material to work with (recommended): Site documentation (pdf/word files, images, etc.) for personal case studies (we will also supply example site documents).

* We'll be happy to advise in advance on AI access and suitable materials

Maximum number of participants: 20